Birbar, too, made an aggressive bid for the job. Such was the fervour of both men that Akbar cast lots to choose between them. Birbar won.

Hakim Abul Fath – bottle-man not battle-man, last seen escaping the rebels in Bengal – went along too. It could not have been a worse pairing: neither Birbar nor Abul Fath had shown any great skill for battle, and, besides, they despised each other.

'On the march there were daily, improper expressions used to one another,' writes Abul Fazl about their unhappy journey. Things only got worse when they reached Zain's camp. Not only did Birbar not get along with Abul Fath, he disliked Zain, too. All along the way, it seems, he muttered in disgust at his situation, 'It looks as if my fortune has been inverted that I should have to traverse hill and plain with the Hakim, for the support of [Zain Khan]. When shall the things end?'[22]

They ended as badly as they had begun. At the very first meeting between the three men, the 'Rajah and the Hakim came from hard language to mutual abuse'. Then, maybe tired of haranguing each other, they joined forces against Zain, who had made a misguided effort to bring peace and proffer a plan. Zain wanted part of the army, now strengthened with reinforcements, to march on to further conquest, and part to stay behind to guard his acquisitions. But no, Birbar and Abul Fath insisted they must all march: 'The orders were to attack the country, not to guard it.'

Akbar's amirs, bound by oaths and devotion to their emperor, were at loggerheads with each other; more fearful of Akbar's disapproval, it seems, than of making bad decisions in an alien land. Thus, Abul Fazl writes that while Zain knew that the newcomers had completely misjudged the dangers of marching jauntily, flanks unguarded, into hostile ravines, he gave in when they insisted because he knew how close Abul Fath and Birbar were to Akbar, and was afraid they would complain about him. Birbar and Abul Fath, meanwhile, were equally afraid 'that they should be disgraced' if they did not act precisely as Akbar had commanded.

On 12 February 1586, therefore, the squabbling generals set off on their 'unsuitable march'. They had some initial victories, but then the Afghans got behind them and attacked. Having, somehow, defended his flank, Zain went to Birbar's tent that evening and made a last-ditch appeal to reason: the Afghans had occupied all the heights nearby; the road ahead would only